

How to start?

Dissertation (EI or ETI)

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Before We Begin: Three Key Questions

What do you want to achieve? achieve?

Define your research goals and expected contributions to your field of study.

Will you benefit from it?

Consider personal and professional growth opportunities this research will provide.

What is your final product?

Envision the tangible outcomes and deliverables of your research project.

These fundamental questions will guide your decision-making throughout the research process and help maintain focus on your objectives.

ISCTE IUL
Instituto Universitário de Lisboa

Departamento de Ciências e Tecnologias da Informação
[Escola de Tecnologias e Arquitectura]

Delegação de Gestão de Identidades
Pesquisa Aplicada a um Caso Prático na Administração Pública Portuguesa

David Diogo Ralo

Dissertação submetida como requisito parcial para obtenção do grau de
Mestre em Informática e Gestão

Orientadora:
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Mestre Maria Henriqueta Almeida,
GeRAP, EPE

Setembro, 2011

What We'll Cover Today



Understanding Research Fundamentals

Explore what research truly means and why it matters for your academic and professional development.



Critical Literature Review

Master the art of analyzing existing research to position your work within academic discourse.



Formulating Your Research Topic

Learn systematic approaches to identify, develop, and refine compelling research questions.



Types of Research: Basic vs Applied

Basic Research

Seeks to expand fundamental understanding without immediate practical application. Focuses on theory development and knowledge advancement.

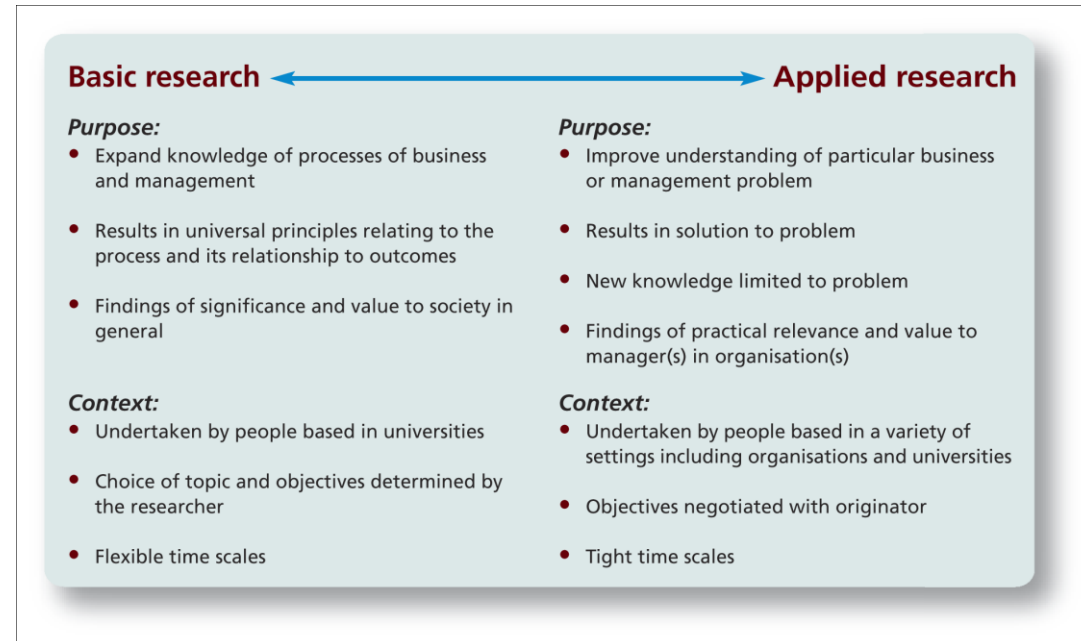
- Theoretical frameworks
- Conceptual models
- Scientific principles

Applied Research

Addresses specific problems or questions with practical implications. Aims to solve real-world challenges using existing knowledge.

- Problem-solving approaches
- Policy recommendations
- Practical applications

Your dissertation may incorporate elements of both types, depending on your research questions and objectives.



Alice's Adventures in Wonderland (Carroll, 1989)

"Would you tell me, please, which way I ought to walk from here?" Alice asked the Cheshire Cat.

"That depends a good deal on where you want to get to," said the Cat.

"I don't much care where," said Alice.

"Then it doesn't matter which way you walk," said the Cat.

❏ **Research Lesson:** Without clear direction and purpose, any path will lead you nowhere meaningful. Define your destination before starting your journey.



Formulating Your Research Topic

Developing a strong research topic requires systematic planning and careful consideration of multiple factors.



Identify Good Topic Attributes

Understand what makes a research topic viable and worthwhile for academic investigation.



Generate Suitable Ideas

Use various techniques to discover potential research areas that align with your interests and expertise.



Develop Clear Questions

Transform broad ideas into specific, measurable research questions and objectives.



Write Research Proposal

Create a comprehensive document that outlines your research plan and methodology.



Capability Assessment: Is It Feasible?

Before committing to a research topic, honestly evaluate whether you can successfully complete the project.

1

Personal Interest & Passion

Are you genuinely fascinated by this topic? Sustained motivation is crucial for long-term research success.

2

Research Skills & Expertise

Do you possess the necessary methodological knowledge, or can you develop these skills within your timeframe?

3

Time Management

Can you realistically complete this project within your program's timeline while maintaining quality standards?

4

Contemporary Relevance

Will your research findings still be current and valuable when you complete your dissertation?

5

Resource Availability

Do you have adequate financial support, equipment, and institutional resources for your research design?

6

Data Access

Can you obtain necessary permissions and access to participants, organizations, or datasets required for your study?

Appropriateness Assessment: Is It Worthwhile?

Beyond feasibility, your research must contribute meaningfully to academic knowledge and your career development.



Theoretical Foundation

Does your topic address issues clearly connected to established theories and academic frameworks?



Question Clarity

Are your research questions and objectives precisely defined and easily understood by others in your field?



Fresh Insights

Will your proposed research generate new understanding or challenge existing assumptions in your discipline?



Career Alignment

Does this research topic support your professional goals and enhance your expertise in desired areas?

These criteria ensure your research investment yields both academic contributions and personal professional development.



No Research Topic Yet? Start Here

If you haven't identified a research topic, these proven techniques will help generate compelling ideas worth investigating.



Rational & Creative Thinking

Combine logical analysis with imaginative exploration to identify gaps in current knowledge and innovative approaches.



Collaborative Brainstorming

Engage with peers, faculty, and professionals to generate diverse perspectives and uncover interdisciplinary connections.



Media & Industry Scanning

Monitor current events, industry reports, and professional publications for timely and relevant research topics.



Literature Exploration

Systematically review recent publications to discover emerging trends, unresolved questions, and research opportunities.



Past Project Analysis

Examine previous dissertations, theses, and research projects to identify areas for extension or improvement.



Academic Discussions

Participate in seminars, conferences, and informal conversations to discover compelling questions and research



Pro Tip: Keep an ideas notebook! Document interesting observations, questions, and insights as they emerge in your daily academic life.

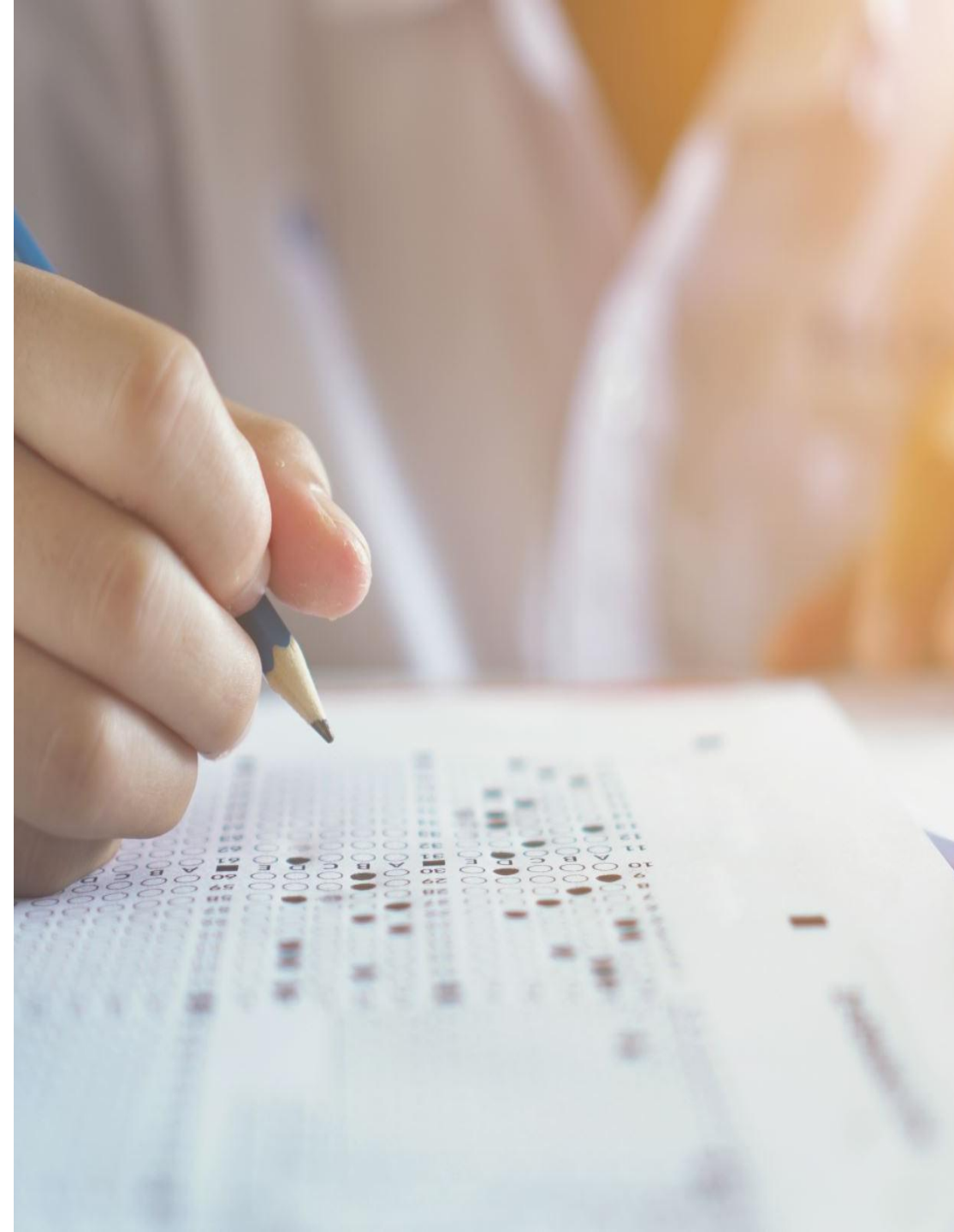
And if I do not have a good research topic... yet?

Rational Thinking	Creative Thinking
☐ Examining your own strengths and interests	☐ Keeping a notebook of ideas
☐ Looking at past project titles	☐ Exploring personal preferences using past projects
☐ Discussion	☐ Relevance Trees
☐ Searching the literature	☐ Brainstorming
☐ Scanning the media	

Writing research questions

Crafting effective research questions is the foundation of successful academic work. Your questions should be:

- Able to produce clear, actionable conclusions
- At the right level - challenging but achievable
- Beyond mere description - seeking deeper understanding
- Passing the "Goldilocks Test" - not too broad, not too narrow, but just right





Research Proposal: Content

- Title: likely to change during the process
- Background: context within the literature
- Research Questions
- Objectives

Mainly, what you seek to achieve!

Research Proposal: Content

- Method: design science research and data collection and validation
- Timescale
- References





Defining the Goal

The **SMART** acronym stand for:

- **Specific:** A specific goal is focused, detailed and clearly stated.
- **Measurable:** A measurable goal is quantitative in nature, meaning you (or a coach) can measure the results.
- **Attainable:** An attainable goal is one that can be accomplished based on the resources and skill of the person trying to complete it.
- **Realistic:** In addition to being attainable, a relevant goal applies to the achiever's desire and current state.
- **Time-bound:** A time-bound goal has specific timelines and a deadline. This will help motivate you to move toward your goal, set milestones (to get early wins) and help you evaluate your progress in case realignment is necessary.

Why Literature Reviews Matter



Preliminary Exploration

Conduct initial searches to understand what existing material is available in your field



Organise Ideas

Structure valuable findings and insights from previous research to inform your approach



Identify Ongoing Work

Discover other research currently in progress to avoid duplication and find collaboration opportunities



Generate New Ideas

Spark innovative research concepts by understanding gaps and opportunities in existing knowledge



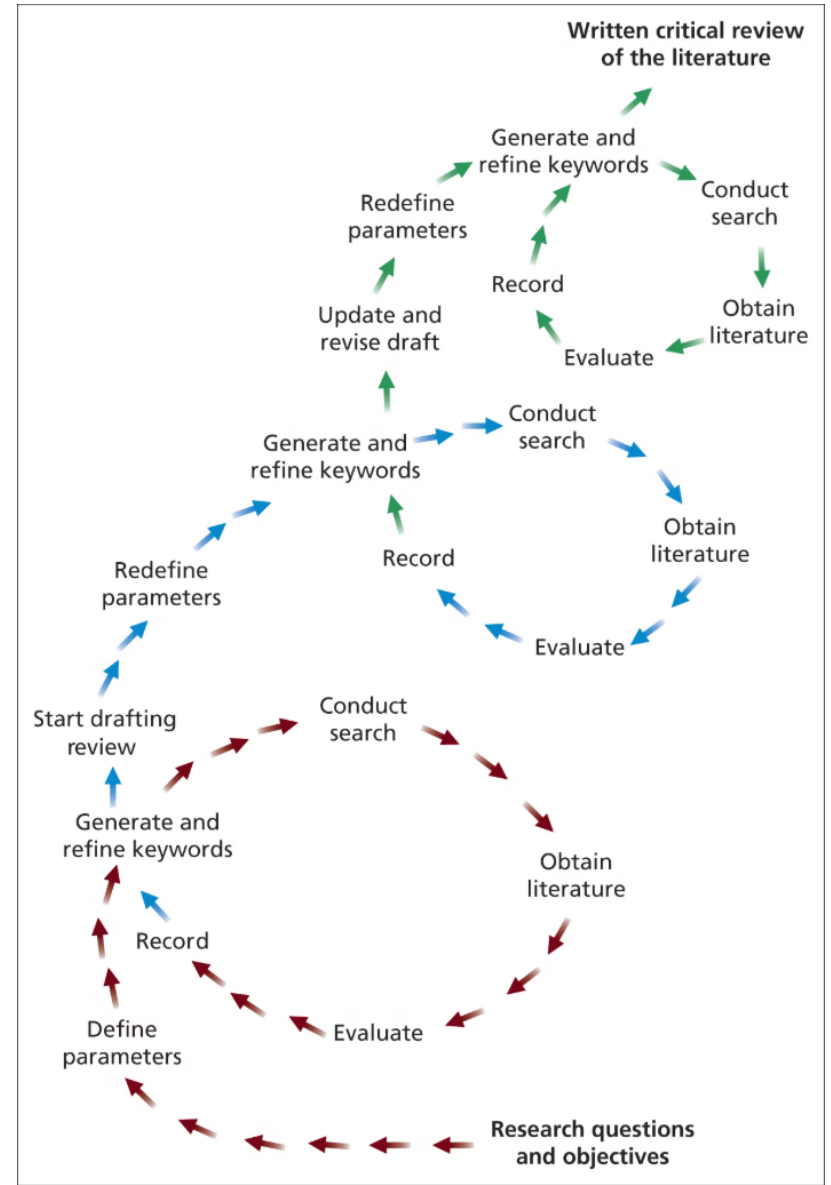
Develop Critical Thinking

Build analytical skills to evaluate, critique, and synthesise academic work effectively

The Literature Review Process

A systematic approach ensures comprehensive coverage whilst maintaining focus on your research objectives.

This cyclical process allows for continuous refinement of your understanding and research direction.



Source: Saunders *et al.* 2003

Critical Review: Key Purposes



Refine Questions

Further sharpen your research questions and objectives based on existing knowledge



Find Recommendations

Discover valuable suggestions for future research directions from established scholars



Avoid Duplication

Prevent repeating work that has already been thoroughly investigated



Learn Strategies

Gain insights into methodologies and techniques suited to your research goals



Essential Skills for Effective Reading



Previewing

Quickly scan texts to identify key themes and relevance before deep reading



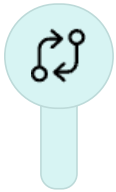
Annotating

Make meaningful notes and highlight crucial passages for future reference



Summarising

Distil complex ideas into concise, actionable insights



Comparing & Contrasting

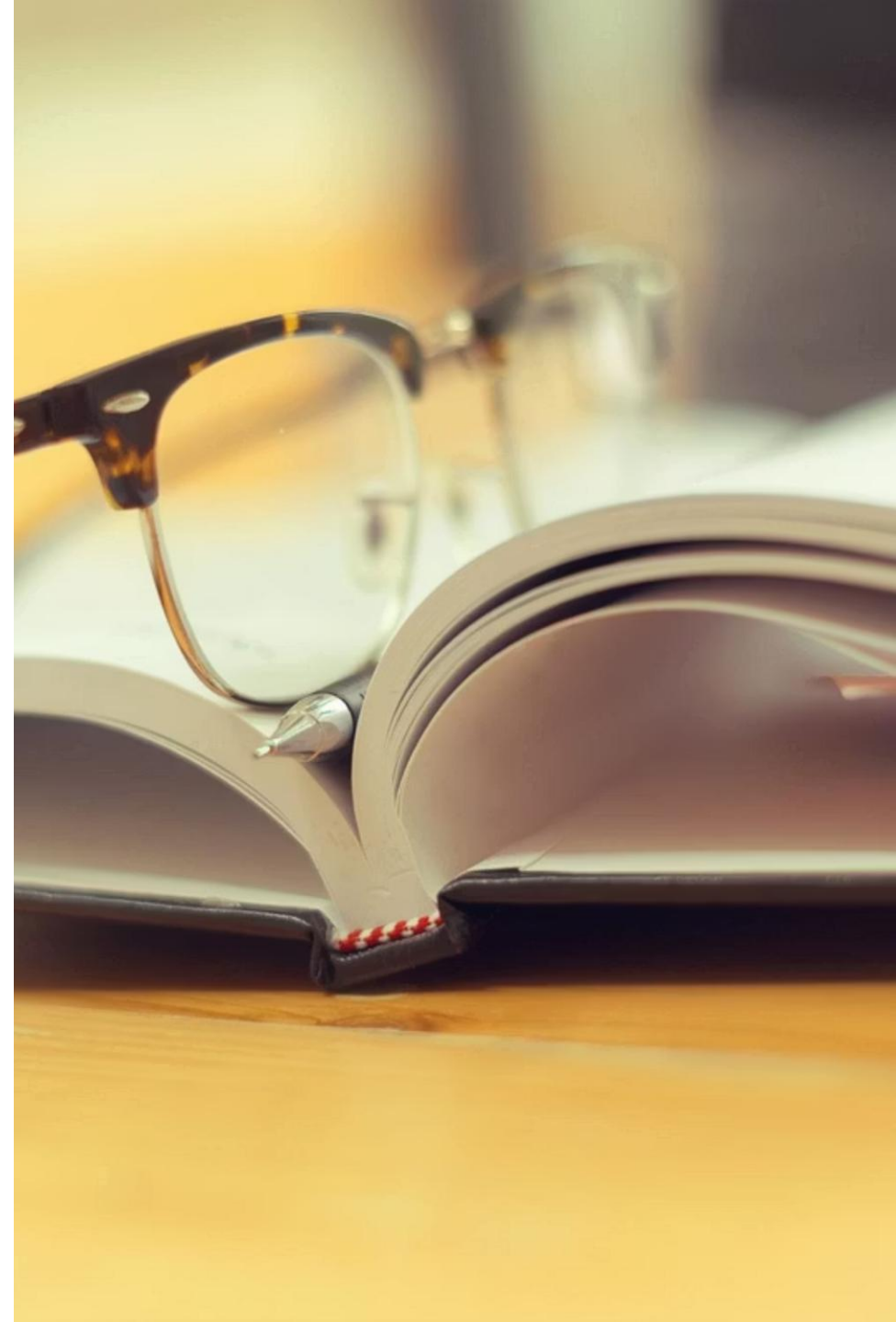
Identify similarities, differences, and gaps between various research approaches

Based on Harvard College Library (2006)

Adopting a critical perspective

- The most important skills are:
 - The capacity to evaluate what you read
 - The capacity to relate what you read to other information
- What should you question?
 - Why am I reading this?
 - What is the author trying to do in writing this?
 - How convincing is this?
 - What use can I make of this reading?

Based on Wallace and Wray (2006)



Content of the Review

- Include key academic theories
- Demonstrate current knowledge of the area
- Use clear referencing for the reader to find the original cited publications
- Acknowledge the research of others



Structure of the literature review

- 3 possible structures:
 - **Single chapter**
 - Series of chapters
 - Throughout the report



What to write ...

- Demonstrate that you have read, understood and evaluated your material
- Link the different ideas to form a cohesive and coherent argument
- Make clear connections to your research objectives and the subsequent empirical material

Based on Saunders *et al. (2009)*



Strategy ...

Write:

- parameters of your search
- key words and search terms to be used
- databases and search engines to be used
- criteria for selection of relevant and useful studies

And: discuss with you supervisor!

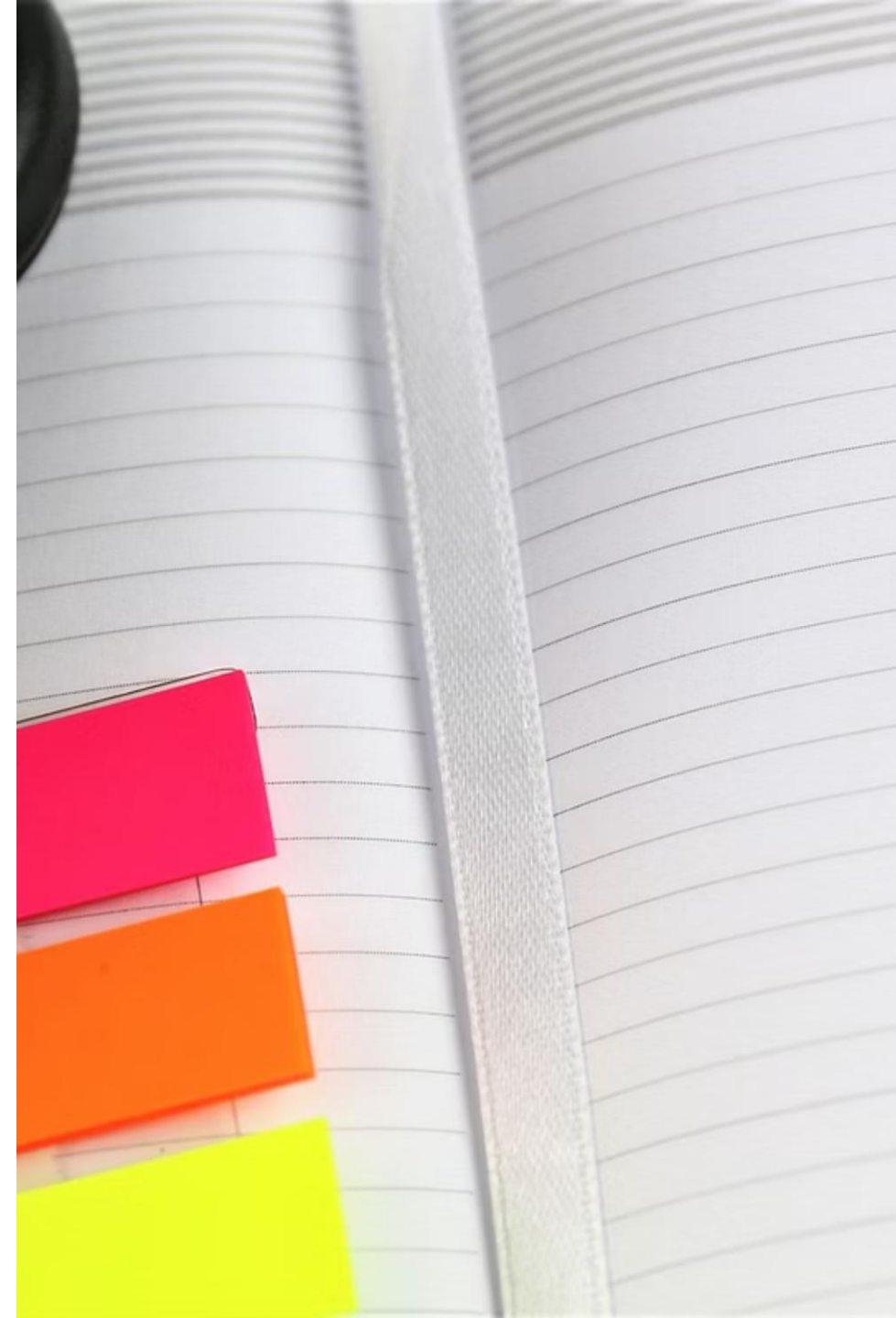


Not to forget!

- Make notes for each item you read
- Record:
 - Biographic details
 - Brief summary of content
 - Supplementary information

Based on Sharp et al. (2002)

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Plagiarism

Stealing material from another source

Submitting material written by another

Copying material without quotation marks

Paraphrasing material without documentation

Adapted from Park (2003), cited in Easterby-Smith *et al.* (2008)

References

Slides produced from the material of the book : **Research Methods for Business Students**, Mark Saunders, 5th Edition ISBN: 9780273716860